



THE COMPLETE GUIDE

# What the NEDS CRM is, why we built it ourselves, and what it's actually doing for us.

A plain-language answer to the questions we get most — from prospects, clients, new teammates, and partners: what is this thing, why not just buy a CRM, and is it working? No sales gloss — the honest version, with real numbers.

Built in-house, since June 2026

India GST built in

Runs our own agency, today

Can be built for other businesses too

## If you only read one slide, read this one.

The NEDS CRM is software our own agency's engineering team built **from scratch**, specifically for how a small Indian digital-services agency actually works: leads that turn into GST-compliant quotations and invoices, recurring retainers alongside one-time project billing, a support desk, a client portal, and AI that helps the team without ever acting on its own. We didn't build it to sell software — we built it because nothing off-the-shelf handled Indian GST invoicing and our mix of retainer + milestone billing well enough. It's not a demo: it's the same system we run our own client billing, quotations and day-to-day work through, right now.



### What it replaced

Spreadsheets for leads, Word for quotations, Excel for GST math, WhatsApp as the only record of a conversation.



### Who it's for

Originally: us. Now: any Indian SMB or agency with a similar mix of recurring + project billing and a GST compliance headache.



### Where AI fits in

Scoring leads, drafting replies, summarizing history — always opt-in, always human-reviewed before anything is sent.

## THE QUESTION EVERYONE ASKS FIRST

# "Zoho and HubSpot already exist. Why build your own?"

Fair question. Here's the honest comparison — not "ours is better," but where the gap actually was for a business like ours.

| What we needed                                     | Generic CRM (Zoho/HubSpot/Salesforce)                                                                     | NEDS CRM                                                                                                    |
|----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| India GST invoicing                                | Bolted on via an add-on or a separate accounting tool; CGST/SGST/IGST split usually needs manual checking | Built into the invoice engine from day one — auto-splits by the client's GSTIN state code, zero manual math |
| Recurring retainer + milestone billing on one deal | Usually one billing model or the other, rarely both cleanly on the same record                            | Native: a single deal can carry a recurring retainer <i>and</i> milestone/advance-balance invoices          |
| Talking to our own delivery tools                  | Needs custom integration work (or doesn't happen)                                                         | Already wired into our service-delivery tool (Drishti) and content tool (SMDost) and WhatsApp               |
| Cost over years, for a small team                  | Per-user, per-month, forever — grows every time we hire                                                   | One-time build + hosting (~₹5–15k/year class of shared hosting) — no per-seat bill                          |
| Who owns the data / can change it                  | Locked into the vendor's platform, roadmap and pricing                                                    | Our own codebase, our own MySQL database, our own hosting — we can change anything                          |

# Custom software isn't always the right call.

If we only told you the upside, you shouldn't trust the rest of this document either. Here's when we'd tell a friend to *not* build custom.

## Stick with off-the-shelf if...

- Your workflow is genuinely standard — a generic CRM's default setup already fits
- You need it running in days, not weeks — a build always takes longer than a signup
- You don't have (or want) anyone in-house who can own a custom system long-term
- Your team is 1–3 people — the per-seat cost of SaaS is trivial at that size

## Build custom if...

- ✓ A specific compliance rule (like GST) keeps needing manual double-checking
- ✓ You're paying for five tools to cover one workflow, none of them talking to each other
- ✓ Your billing model (retainer + milestone, subscriptions, package pricing) doesn't fit a generic deal/pipeline model
- ✓ You plan to still be running this in 5+ years and per-seat cost will have compounded

IS IT ACTUALLY WORKING? — REAL NUMBERS, NOT A PITCH

# What's genuinely running through it today.

Pulled from our own production database, not a demo environment.

66

active clients managed in the system

62

GST invoices generated — tax split  
automatically every time

43

quotations built and sent through the system

72

payments recorded against those invoices

## What's a genuine daily habit already

- **Billing:** every quotation and GST invoice for the agency now goes through here — no more Word/Excel math
- **Work tracking:** 343 tasks logged across projects and clients
- **Calls:** 94 client calls logged, feeding the team performance view

## What's still becoming a habit

- Sales pipeline stage-tracking (deals) and support ticket logging adopted more slowly than billing — the team's muscle memory for those is still forming
- We track this on purpose: a system nobody actually uses is worse than no system — so we review real usage numbers, not just "is the feature built," every two weeks

## DEPENDS WHO'S ASKING

# The same system, four different questions.

** A prospect asks: "Can you build this for me?"**

Yes — two ways. Either we license this exact system, reconfigured for your services and branding (fast), or we use it as the proven foundation for something built to your specific workflow (e.g. a different industry — see the vertical one-pagers). Either way you're not our first attempt at this — it's already handling real money.

** A client asks: "Why do I have a login to this?"**

So you can see your own quotations, invoices, project status and support tickets without calling or messaging to ask "where's my invoice." It's read-only and only shows your own data — nobody else's.

** A new teammate asks: "Do I have to use this?"**

Yes, for anything client-facing — leads, quotations, invoices, tickets, tasks. It's not extra admin on top of your job; it's meant to replace the WhatsApp/Excel version of the same work, and it feeds your own performance and attendance reports.

** A partner/collaborator asks: "How does this fit with your other tools?"**

It's the hub. It already talks to our service-delivery tool (Drishti) and AI content tool (SMDost) — a client won by the CRM is auto-provisioned in both, and work approved in either flows back here as billing. It's built to integrate, not sit alone.

## THE FOLLOW-UP QUESTION

# "I run a different kind of business — can I get one too?"

Usually, yes. What changes is how much of this system carries over as-is versus needs real rework for your workflow.

## What's genuinely reusable for almost any business

- The GST invoicing/quotation engine — tax rules are universal across service businesses
- Client portal, role-based access, activity logging, 2FA, automated backups
- AI patterns: opt-in lead scoring, draft replies, thread summaries — the discipline of "AI helps, never auto-sends" applies everywhere
- Runs cheaply on shared hosting — no infra team required to keep it alive

## What has to be rebuilt for your workflow

- The pipeline shape (our "Lead → Deal → Project" doesn't fit every business)
- Whatever your business actually sells — a physical product, a booking, a subscription seat — needs its own data model, not a relabeled version of ours
- Industry-specific compliance beyond GST (e.g. sector-specific document rules)

See the companion one-pager for a worked example: what a build for a **Tours & Travel** business would actually look like.

## THE SKEPTICAL QUESTIONS

# Common objections, answered straight.

**Q: "Isn't a small agency building its own software a distraction from client work?"**

A: It was built by the same Software Development team we sell to clients — using it internally is also how we stress-test our own build quality before we sell it.

**Q: "What happens if the person who built it leaves?"**

A: It's standard Laravel/PHP/MySQL — a common, well-documented stack any competent developer can pick up. It's not a one-person black box.

**Q: "Is our data safe in a custom system vs. a big-name CRM?"**

A: Two-factor authentication, per-role permission policies (not just hidden menus), a full audit log of every change, and automated nightly backups — the same habits a bigger vendor would sell you, without the per-seat markup.

**Q: "Are you just going to keep changing it forever?"**

A: It changes when a real workflow gap shows up — not on a vendor's release calendar. Every change ships behind automated tests (400+ and growing) covering GST math, billing and permissions specifically, so it doesn't regress.

**Q: "Isn't AI risky with client and financial data?"**

A: AI is opt-in, wrapped so a failure never breaks a core workflow, and never sends anything without a human clicking Send. It never touches invoicing, payments or contracts.

WANT TO SEE IT, NOT JUST READ ABOUT IT?

# Ask for a live walkthrough.

The strongest answer to "is this real?" is a five-minute look at the actual system — a lead, a GST quotation, an invoice, a support ticket, all connected. No slides needed for that part.

## Related documents

- Sales & Marketing Pitch Deck — the internal, angle-based sales version
- Tours & Travel — AI Solution one-pager — a worked vertical example

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